Course Feedback and Responses

14.33 Research and Communication in Economics

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October 26, 2026

General takeaways

- Positive sentiment about overall course structure and learning goals
- Changes to meeting agendas and peer feedback structure based on feedback

Learning goals

- No response of any learning goal not on track to be met
- Supermajority of “maybe” for version-controlled, one-click reproducible research pipeline
- Otherwise supermajorities/unanimity for “yes”

Version control, reproducibility, and AI tooling

- Large variation in prior experience
- Free text feedback to give more practical suggestions
- **Changes**:
  - → Proactive (non-graded) auditing of GitHub repos to provide feedback on current practices
  - → Experiment with peer feedback knowledge sharing

Peer feedback

- Majority favored current size, with others favoring smaller groups
- Free text sentiment positive, but noting desire for more structure and less disruption
- Very positive sentiment about verbal communication activities
- **Changes**:
  - → Experiment with groups of two who have the same meeting time
  - → Experiment with more verbal presentation practice

1-on-1 meeting agendas

- Supermajorities with positive sentiment, without negative sentiment, and wanting 12 hour due date
- **Changes**:
  - → Amend due date to 12 hours beforehand
  - → Trim down agenda to try making pre-meeting review still feasible

Lectures

- Supermajorities like current pace, difficulty, and participation
- Some thought too fast or too difficult
  - → Office hours, meeting issues, and/or email
- Free text sentiment for class to use pre-class assignment
- **Changes**: None (for two remaining lectures)

Unsolicited advice

- **Be proactive about feedback/surfacing issues**
  - → No continuous feedback responses after first week and 3/10 non-responses to mandatory mid-course feedback
  - → Future managers will not be as enthusiastic about soliciting information, but it is even more important for you to surface it then
- **Prioritize sleep**
  - → Giuntella et al (2026) JPE RCT nudged US college students to increase sleep, which on average causally increased sleep by 19 minutes/night and GPA by 0.08 points
- **Lean into struggle**
  - → Independent research is hard, but you learn by doing and iterating

Reminder on grade components

- 5% of grade is final code quality and replicability
  - → Ensure code is reproducible as you go rather than trying to fix it up at the end
- 25% of grade is final exam
  - → Ensure you understand your work as you go rather than "studying" at the end
  - → Example question: "Referee suggests [X] would be a problem for your identification strategy. Explain why that is or isn't the case."

Next assignment: initial paper draft

- Due date pushed to Tuesday 11/3 (1 day later than previous syllabus)
- No penalty for placeholders of planned results
  - → But feedback will be better with actual results
- No bonus for length
  - → Graded on the information you communicate, not the number of words it takes to do so
- Must include:
  1. Introduction
  2. Data section with (some) actual summary statistics
  3. Topic sentences for paragraphs with placeholder of planned results